

Review with Games

Repetition without boredom.

WEEK

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Why it works

Spring review usually means packets, and packets are hardest on the students who read most slowly. Quick games give the same repetition with more talk, more laughter, and far more turns for every student.

How to do it

- 1 Choose a game that needs almost no preparation.**
A whiteboard, two piles of cards, or the projector.
- 2 Make every student answer every time.**
No game where one student plays and thirty watch.
- 3 Keep it to five minutes.**
Short and daily beats long and rare.

What it looks like

Name That ...	Show a clue; the class calls out the category. Speed up each round.
Two corners	Read a statement. Students walk to "true" or "false" and tell a neighbor why.
Whiteboard relay	Teams pass one board; each person adds one step or one word.
Sort it	Pairs sort cards into two or three piles and defend one choice.
Find the fib	Three statements, one false. Partners find it and fix it.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Plays with a partner; answers by pointing or sorting.	Emerging Answers with a word or phrase.	Progressing Explains the answer to the team.	Challenge Writes new clues or cards for the class.
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Try it this week

Replace one review worksheet with a five-minute game in which every student responds every time.

What a visitor would see

Students on their feet or holding whiteboards, all answering at once, and laughing.

Use the Home Language as a Tool

Two languages are an advantage. Treat them like one.

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Why it works

Students think most deeply in the language they know best. When they may use it to plan, discuss, and check understanding, the English they produce afterward is better. English stays the language of the final product; Spanish becomes the scaffold that gets them there.

How to do it

- 1 Preview in the home language.**
A two-minute partner talk or a translated summary before the lesson.
- 2 Teach and produce in English.**
The reading, the discussion report, and the written product.
- 3 Review in the home language.**
"Tell your partner in Spanish what you learned today."

What it looks like

Bilingual glossaries	Students keep their own, by unit. It is a study tool they build themselves.
Language partners	Seat same-language partners together for planning, and mix them for reporting.
Notes in any language	Notes are thinking. The product is what you grade.
You do not need to speak it	You can see whether the talk is on task, and the English product tells you the rest.
What to avoid	Translating everything for them. The goal is a bridge, not a detour.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Plans in the home language; produces labels and words in English.	Emerging Plans in the home language; writes framed sentences in English.	Progressing Uses the home language only to check a difficult idea.	Challenge Explains a concept in both languages to a newer student.
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Try it this week

Once this week, end class with: "Tell your partner in your home language what you learned." Watch what happens to the exit ticket.

What a visitor would see

Students planning in two languages and producing in English, with glossaries open on desks.

Technology That Helps

The Chromebook can be a scaffold or a shortcut.

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Why it works

Translation and voice tools are already in students' hands. Banning them does not work, and ignoring them wastes a real support. The question is when a tool builds English and when it replaces it. A simple rule settles most cases.

How to do it

- 1 Use tools to get in, not to get out.**
Translate to understand the task or the text; write the answer in your own English.
- 2 Turn on the built-in supports.**
Captions on every video, read-aloud for long texts, voice typing for drafts.
- 3 Ask for the process.**
"Show me your draft and what you changed."
Translated work has no drafts.

What it looks like

Captions	On, in English, for every video. They help every reader in the room.
Read-aloud	Students listen while following the text. It supports decoding without replacing reading.
Voice typing	Good for getting a first draft down. The revision is where the learning is.
Translation	Fine for a word, a direction, or a preview. Not for the paragraph that is being graded.
Check the plan	Some tools are also testing accommodations. If a student has one, use it all year.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Uses translation to understand directions and key words.	Emerging Uses read-aloud and a glossary; writes framed sentences independently.	Progressing Uses voice typing for a draft, then revises by hand.	Challenge Uses tools only to check, and can explain each choice.
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Try it this week

Turn on English captions for every video this week, and state your translation rule to each class.

What a visitor would see

Captions on the screen, students using read-aloud with headphones, and a clear posted rule about translation.

When a Newcomer Arrives in Spring

The first week decides how the year ends.

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Why it works

New students arrive all year, sometimes weeks before testing. A student with no English on day one can still belong on day one. Belonging comes first, because a frightened student learns nothing. A short routine makes the first week manageable for the student and for you.

How to do it

- 1 Assign a buddy and a seat before the student walks in.**
Near the front, next to someone patient. Same language if possible.
- 2 Give a survival kit.**
A schedule with pictures, a map, key phrases, and your name written down.
- 3 Give real work on day one.**
Labeling, matching, copying key vocabulary, a drawing of the concept.

What it looks like

Learn the name	Ask how to say it. Write it down the way it sounds. Use it.
Survival phrases	"May I go to the restroom?" "I don't understand." "Can you repeat that?" "Where is ___?"
Expect silence	A silent period of weeks is normal. Keep including, keep waiting.
Tell your EL specialist	They can meet the student, check records, and set up supports quickly.
State testing	New arrivals may have different testing rules. Ask your EL specialist before assuming anything.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Day one: a buddy, a seat, a schedule, a name learned.	Emerging Week one: labels, matching, and one spoken phrase a day.	Progressing Month one: framed sentences and partner talk.	Challenge Becomes the buddy for the next new student.
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Try it this week

Put together a newcomer folder now: picture schedule, map, survival phrases, and a labeled diagram from your current unit.

What a visitor would see

A newcomer folder ready in every room, and new students seated with a buddy on their first day.

Culture as Content

Students learn from people who know who they are.

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Why it works

Our English learners bring knowledge we rarely ask for: other school systems, other histories, farming, construction, caring for siblings, crossing borders. Connecting content to that knowledge is not a detour from the standards. It is how new information attaches to old.

How to do it

- 1 Get the names right.**
Ask, practice, and correct yourself out loud. It matters more than it seems.
- 2 Ask what students already know about the topic.**
From home, from another country, from work.
- 3 Widen your examples.**
Word problems, texts, and historical cases from more than one place.

In your subject

ELA	Pair a class text with a story or proverb from students' home cultures and compare themes.
Math	Use the metric system as an asset, and exchange rates or recipes for real proportional reasoning.
Science	Ask about climates, crops, and animals students know firsthand.
Social studies	Compare founding documents, independence days, and governments.
What to avoid	Asking one student to speak for a whole country, or putting anyone's immigration story on display.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Shares a word, a food, a place, or a picture.	Emerging Tells one fact about how something is done at home.	Progressing Compares a class topic with home knowledge in sentences.	Challenge Teaches the class something and takes questions.
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Try it this week

In one lesson this week, ask, "Where have you seen this before?" and wait for answers that come from outside the United States.

What a visitor would see

Examples and texts from more than one culture, and names pronounced correctly.

State Test Week

Nothing new. Everything familiar.

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Why it works

By test week the teaching is done. What helps now is calm, routine, and exactly the supports each student's plan lists, given the way they have been given all year. What hurts is anything new: a new room, a new tool, or a new rule.

How to do it

- 1 Follow the test administration manual exactly.**
It decides what may and may not be said or provided.
- 2 Provide each student's listed supports, and only those.**
Your test coordinator and EL specialist can confirm them.
- 3 Keep the week normal.**
Same greetings, same routines, a lighter load in non-tested classes.

What it looks like

The day before	Tell students where to go, what to bring, and how long it lasts. Say it, write it, send it home.
The morning of	A calm greeting at the door. No last-minute review.
During	You may not explain, translate, or rephrase test content unless the manual and the plan allow it.
After	No discussion of test items. A quiet activity, and thanks.
Other classes	Expect tired students. It is a good week for games, projects, and reading for pleasure.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Knows the room, the time, and the tools on the screen.	Emerging Uses the listed supports the same way as in class.	Progressing Uses the break routine and the plan for being stuck.	Challenge Encourages classmates and models calm.
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Try it this week

Confirm with your EL specialist or test coordinator which supports your English learners receive. Then plan a light week in untested classes.

What a visitor would see

Calm hallways, familiar routines, and students who know exactly where to go and what to expect.

Projects and Presentations

Speaking in front of the class is the hardest task we assign.

Why it works

End-of-year projects often end with a presentation, which combines public speaking, a second language, and an audience of peers. With rehearsal and structure, English learners can do it well, and it is often the moment they discover they can.

How to do it

- 1 Give a structure for the talk.**
Opening, three points, closing, each with a starter.
- 2 Rehearse three times.**
To a partner, to a small group, and once on video.
- 3 Grade content and delivery separately.**
And offer options: present to a small group, or record it.

What it looks like

Openers	"Today I will explain ____." · "My topic is ____ because ____."
Signposts	"First ..." · "Another reason is ..." · "Finally ..."
Closers	"In conclusion, ____." · "Thank you. Are there any questions?"
Note cards	Key words and frames, not full sentences to read aloud.
Audience job	Each listener writes one thing learned and one question. It keeps the room kind.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Presents a labeled poster with a partner and says three rehearsed sentences.	Emerging Presents with note cards to a small group.	Progressing Presents to the class using signposts.	Challenge Presents and answers unscripted questions.
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Try it this week

For your next presentation, require three rehearsals and give the audience a listening job.

What a visitor would see

Students rehearsing in pairs with note cards, and audiences writing a question for each speaker.

Celebrate the Growth

Show them how far they have come.

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Why it works

Language growth is slow and invisible to the person doing the growing. A student who wrote labels in August and paragraphs in May may honestly not know it. Putting the two side by side is the strongest motivation we can offer, and it costs nothing.

How to do it

- 1 Find an August sample.**
A first writing piece, an early recording, or a first quiz.
- 2 Put it next to a May sample.**
Let the student find the differences first.
- 3 Name the growth specifically.**
"In August you wrote four words. Today you wrote four sentences with because."

What it looks like

Side by side	August and May writing on one page, with the student's own list of what changed.
Listen back	An early recording and a new one. Students are astonished.
Tell the family	A note home in the family's language about one specific thing that grew.
Tell the student's other teachers	Growth noticed in one room should be known in all of them.
Recognize effort publicly, and scores privately	Every student can be praised for growth. Not every student wants a level announced.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer From silence to spoken sentences.	Emerging From labels to framed sentences.	Progressing From sentences to paragraphs.	Challenge From correct to precise, and from helped to helper.
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Try it this week

Pick three English learners. Put an August sample beside a May sample and let each student tell you what changed.

What a visitor would see

Students holding two pieces of their own work and explaining the difference.

Hand Off and Reflect

What next year's teacher needs to know.

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Why it works

Every fall we spend six weeks rediscovering what last year's teacher already knew. A three-line note ends that. And before the year closes, it is worth asking which of these thirty-six moves became part of how you teach.

How to do it

- 1 Write three lines for each English learner.**
What the student can do, what helps most, and what to try next.
- 2 Send it to your EL specialist.**
It can be attached to the student's file and passed to next year's teachers.
- 3 Choose your three.**
Which three moves will you keep? Which one do you want help with in August?

What it looks like

Can do	"Writes a full paragraph with starters. Speaks up in pairs, rarely in whole group."
What helps	"Seat near the board. Frames for explaining. Preview vocabulary the day before."
Try next	"Ready to drop the frames in science. Needs a push to speak to the whole class."
For the summer	Encourage reading in any language, and a public library card. Reading in Spanish builds English reading.
For your EL specialist	Note which cards helped, which did not, and what you want next year.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Note: strengths, supports that worked, first goal for fall.	Emerging Note: which frames to keep, which to remove.	Progressing Note: ready for fewer supports; next target.	Challenge Note: ready to exit supports; keep checking in.
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Try it this week

Write the three-line note for each English learner on your roster and send it to your EL specialist before the last day.

What a visitor would see

A short note in every English learner's file, and a staff that knows which three moves it is keeping.